there and then, how much I loved our brand new baby son. I could feel my heart grow to make room for the new life in our lives.

The best moment of all was still waiting to happen. My mum looked after Brooklyn while we were in the operating room. His first glimpse of his baby brother was about half an hour after Romeo was born. It was my first glimpse, as well, of the two of them together. The most wonderful feeling: Brooklyn looked down at this tiny little creature, wrapped up in fresh linen, and he just melted. He was so gentle with Romeo, so loving. He reached out and stroked his brother's forehead, the lightest of touches. I was standing there watching. No need to tell Brooklyn to be careful. He was only three years old himself, but already wise enough to know how precious Romeo was. They connected. It's been like that between the two of them ever since. I'd always wanted a baby brother. I was looking at my eldest son now and the way he was with Romeo was the way I'm sure I would have been. Those two boys together for those couple of minutes, the two of them touching, a little world of their own: their dad had never felt so happy, never felt so proud.

I like the feeling that those two boys are with me, even when I'm away from home. And not just in my heart. I had their name tattooed on my back after each one was born. There's a guardian angel there, too, looking after them both. My dad had three tattoos of his own and so the idea has been with me since I was a kid. In Dad's case, I think it was a bit of a teenage rebellion thing. I know he got a clip round the ear when Grandad found out about them. My equivalent of that was getting my ear pierced when I was fifteen, at a jeweller's in Chingford Mount. Dad went mad:

'What have you done that for? What are people going to say when you turn up for soccer with an earring?'

He was about as pleased with my little silver hoop as his dad had been when he pulled off the plaster hiding Dad's first tattoo. When I was a boy I sometimes talked about getting one. Mum would wince but Dad, obviously, would have been happy enough. I never seemed to get round to it then; I suppose I was waiting for the right time. It never occurred to me to have one because I liked a particular design; I didn't think about them as a fashion thing. The idea came up much later, a little while after Brooklyn was born. I was talking to Mel B and her then-husband, Jimmy Gulzar, and the subject of tattoos came up. I ended up going to this Dutch guy who'd done all of Jimmy's. I'd finally realized what I wanted a tattoo to represent. Mine are all about the people in my life, my wife and sons, who I want to have with me always. When you see me, you see the tattoos. You see an expression of how I